



Icaronycteris

ICK-ah-roe-NICK-teh-riss



- **When** 55–50 million years ago (Paleogene)
- **Fossil location** USA
- **Habitat** Woodlands of N. America
- **Length** 1 ft (0.3 m)
- **Diet** Insects

We know *Icaronycteris* was a night-flying bat that caught prey in midair because moth scales have been found in the stomach of one fossil. To catch moths at night, modern bats send out pulses of sound and use the echoes to “see” in the dark (echolocation). The structure of *Icaronycteris*’s inner ear suggests it was able to use echolocation, too.



▲ ICARONYCTERIS is one of the earliest known bats. Unlike some modern bats, its long tail was not connected to its hindlimbs by a flap of skin. However, it did sleep hanging upside down from a tree branch or a cave roof.

LIVING RELATIVE

Bats are the only true flying mammals. They have membranes of skin between their arms and fingers, which have evolved into long wings. Some bats, such as this fruit bat, or flying fox, feed on fruit instead of insects.

